



In a striking display of sportspersonship, the Khelo India Youth Games 2023 unfolded in Tamil Nadu, captivating sports enthusiasts nationwide. The event was a grand success with its intense competition, remarkable record-breaking feats, and a jubilant atmosphere that united athletes, officials and the entire sports community. This sporting spectacle not only solidified Tamil Nadu's position as a sporting powerhouse but also showcased the state's adeptness in efficiently hosting major sports events in a brief timeframe.

Marking its debut in South India, the 6th edition of the Khelo India Youth Games transformed into a re-joining celebration of sports, a vision championed by Honourable Chief Minister Thiru. M K Stalin and Honourable Minister for Youth Welfare and Sports Development, Thiru. Udhayanidhi Stalin. In a momentous opening ceremony on January 19, the esteemed Prime Minister Thiru. Narendra Modi inaugurated the Khelo India Youth Games 2023.

Distinguished guests added to the grandeur, with the presence of the Honourable Governor of Tamil Nadu Thiru. R N Ravi, Honourable Union Minister of Youth Affairs and Sports, Information and Broadcasting Thiru. Anurag Singh Thakur, Honourable Union Minister of State, Home Affairs, Youth Affairs and Sports, Thiru. Nisith Pramanik, Honourable Minister of State for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying and Information and Broadcasting Thiru. L Murugan.

The grand opening ceremony was preceded by promotional activities that the Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu had launched to spread the spirit and message of the Games across the state. Five specially designed Canters with the ceremonial torch (Thamizh) started from Chennai, Madurai, Trichy and

Coimbatore and visited all 38 districts before reaching the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium ahead of the opening ceremony. It is noteworthy that this was the first time historical figures were used as the logo and mascot of the Games. The great poet and saint Thiruvalluvar, whose works encompass diverse aspects of life and offer insights into Tamil literature, was given a pride of place in the logo. The mascot, Veera Mangai, symbolising the valour and spirit of Indian women, was an apt tribute to Velu Nachiyar, the first Indian queen to wage a war against British colonial rule.

The State's commitment to promoting sports was evident through various promotional activities and fan engagement initiatives, such as Khelo Carnival and Beach Fest, contributing to the overall success of the Games. The grand inauguration ceremony not only set the stage for a fortnight of intense competition but also celebrated the cultural heritage of Tamil Nadu, underscoring the importance of unity and collaboration in the pursuit of sporting excellence.

Drawing participation from nearly 5500 athletes representing 36 states and Union Territories, the games unfolded across 13 days, featuring 26 sports disciplines and offering a total of 929 medals. Chennai, Coimbatore, Madurai and Trichy served as the host cities for the competition, with 21 sports disciplines taking place in 12 world-class venues in Chennai.

For the first time in the history of the Khelo India Youth Games, young athletes in the country were able to compete at venues that have hosted major international competitions such as the ATP Chennai Open, Nehru Cup football, international squash meets, and the Asian Hockey Champions Trophy.

